

The Wethersfield Historic District Commission held a meeting from the Wethersfield Town Hall, Conference Room #3, 505 Silas Deane Highway, Wethersfield, Connecticut on February 28, 2023.

Members Present: Jennifer Wolf, Chairperson
Mark Raymond, Vice Chairperson
Chris Lyons, Clerk
Chris Hall
Tim Gothers
Bruce Cutkomp, Alternate
Katie Symonds, Alternate

Not Present: Damien Cregeau, Alternate
Linda Messina, Recording Secretary

Also Present: Kim Wolf, Historic District Coordinator

Commissioner Wolf called the meeting to order at 7:28 PM, and read the opening comments. Commissioner Lyons read the Legal Notice as it appeared in the *Rare Reminder* on February 16, 2023.

Application #8054-23 Brigid Kennedy and Stephen Haynes, seeking to install twelve Tesla rooftop solar panels on rear roof of home at 285 Garden Street. (Last day to act: March 14, 2023)

Brigid Kennedy and Stephen Haynes, 285 Garden Street, appeared before the Commission. They would like to install 12 Tesla rooftop solar panels on rear surface of main house. A petition from their neighbors showing that they are in favor of the panels on the back roof was submitted for the record. Commissioner Lyons asked about the conduit and the meter and where they would be located. A drawing was provided showing the inverter and A/C disconnect. **UPDATE** - Brigid Kennedy and Stephen Haynes, 285 Garden Street, and Craig Gustav, a representative from Tesla, 714 Brook Street, Rocky Hill, appeared before the Commission. They have adjusted the proposal and they would like to put 12 panels on the back of the main house. That is the minimum number of panels they can have. Drawings were submitted showing the location of the mechanicals. The conduits will go straight up the wall on the outside. It can be run inside and straight up from the inverter. It would offset beyond the plane of the gutter and there would be a 4" conduit cover. There would be 12" of exposed conduit on the roof to the first panel. They could go through the attic space so nothing would overhang the gutter.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application. There being no one, this portion of the hearing was declared closed.

Application #8057-23 Juliano's Pools, seeking to install a 4' black aluminum fence in rear yard to surround an 18'x36' in-ground pool at 56 Broad Street. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

Douglas Ovian, 56 Broad Street, appeared before the Commission. They would like to install a fence around the in-ground pool. They don't plan on having a ladder or a railing. The proposal is for a black powder coated stainless steel fence that would be 4' tall. Documentation was provided. There will be a gate facing the barn and a larger gate toward the back. The more forward gate would be for an individual and would be 4' wide. Possible alternative fences were provided. The fence was inspired by a neighbor's wood fence with a mesh screen. Photo was provided. The first choice would be the stainless steel fence. **UPDATE** – Douglas Ovian, 56 Broad Street, appeared before the Commission.

Detail and spec sheets on the fences were provided. He is looking for a minimal look because the pool will be screened. The other options are more triple rail (which is not his first choice). It would be in black. He thinks there will be too much triple rail. They could also match the neighbor's pool at 40. That's not really what he wants for an alternative either. The first alternative is minimal and is wire on wood. He's trying to replicate the look of a garden fence. It would be sufficient for code. The house was built in 1764. The site line is over 150' back. Commissioner Wolf stated that it is wide open though. It's only 1/3 of the property as you look at it. The greenspace will be bigger than the pool between the pool and the barn and there will be a 11' strip between the fence and the fence.

Application #8058-23 William and Nicole Liska, seeking to construct an 8'x21' open porch on front of home with TimberTech Porch flooring in Coastline color and TimberTech railings in matte white color, ThermaTru entry door, Palight trimboards, Abtco beaded ceiling, and carriage-style light fixture at 21 Chesterfield Road. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

William and Nicole Liska, 21 Chesterfield Road, appeared before the Commission. They would like to construct an 8'x21' open porch on the front of the house. Documentation/plans were submitted which include elevations. Roofing material will match existing. Flooring will be TimberTech in Coastline color and railings will be TimberTech in matte white color. A photo of the ceiling was provided. It's a vinyl soffit material that matches the other porch. There will be two steps made of the same material. The skirting will be a picture frame with gray and white. The existing gutter will be moved forward. The lighting will be changed to match the post light. Information is in the documentation that was submitted. They may have two or three recessed lights and ceiling fans. The front door will be $\frac{3}{4}$ glass and a light yellow. **UPDATE** - William and Nicole Liska, 21 Chesterfield Road, appeared before the Commission. The ceiling material was an 8" vinyl panel that was put on the porch that presently exists. They want to duplicate that. The concern was if they had looked at other materials. They met with the builder and went to the lumber yard. One concern was whether the 4'x8' sheet would hold up and not sag. They have decided to stay with what they originally proposed. The elevations that were submitted were to scale, but the dimensions were put together and submitted. The skirt will be the same material and same dimensions as the floor but it won't have tongue and groove and it will be the same color as the flooring and stair treads. There will be recessed lighting and fans.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application.

Damien Cregeau, 493 Main Street, made suggestions about the application.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application. There being no one, this portion of the hearing was declared closed.

Application #8059-23 Ekret Llukaj, seeking to reface front steps and lower portion of front porch with stone veneer, install railings, and stone pillars in front of home at 6-8 Middletown Avenue. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

Klejvi and Ekret Llukaj, 6 Middletown Avenue, appeared before the Commission. They tried to repair the steps previously. They covered the existing steps and siding with veneer and didn't realize that they needed a permit. The siding had asbestos so they covered it. Sample stone was provided. **UPDATE** - Klejvi and Ekret Llukaj, 6 Middletown Avenue, appeared before the Commission. They were unaware that they had to pull permits. Some of the steps had to be taken because the steps were coming apart and the mailman fell. The railings on the sides have been there for several years.

The stone face on the house is inappropriate for the house and it doesn't fit in the neighborhood at all. The columns are not appropriate either. The latticework should be removed. Photos were provided. He would have to break all of the walls, but he can fix the bottom. The lights can be taken down.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application. There being no one, this portion of the hearing was declared closed.

Application #8061-23 Michael Lueken, seeking to install a 3'6" high iron fence in front yard with five (5) 5'6" high bluestone columns to be constructed between fence sections at 362 Middletown Avenue.

Michael Lueken, 362 Middletown Avenue, appeared before the Commission. Additional material was provided. Instead of bluestone posts, they will have iron posts. A photo was provided. Commissioner Wolf stated that the wrought iron fence is a little ornate and asked if they had looked at any simpler designs. It was felt that there is just too much detail for the house. There will be an additional landscaping project as well and they would like it all to blend together. Houses with potential fences were shown on the screen. There is one on Center and Woodland. Another one is on Center Street near Lucky Lou's. They would like to install a cobblestone walkway in the front. A sample of the stone and/or a booklet will be provided.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application. There being no one, this portion of the hearing was declared closed.

Application #8062-23 Brendan Droney, seeking to install 19 roof-mounted solar panels on front and rear roofs of home at 19 Middletown Avenue.

Applicant was not present.

Application #8063-23 Natalie Real, seeking to install a 73' long wood floating dock into the Cove at 310 Hartford Avenue.

Applicant was not present.

Application #8064-23 Earthlight Technologies, seeking to install 14 roof-mounted solar panels on rear roof of home at 77 State Street.

Ian Bucholz, Earthlight Technologies, 128 West Road, Ellington, and Gary Giumetti, 77 State Street, appeared before the Commission. They would like to install 14 roof-mounted solar panels on the rear roof of home. There are very distant glancing views from Hartford Avenue. Handouts were submitted showing the layouts of the panels. The last page shows the locations of the mechanicals. The AC disconnect will be outside. The rest of the solar equipment will be located in the basement. The conduit will go into the attic and punch out the gable end, run next to the rake and down to the service riser. The conduit can be painted to match the house after the inspection.

Commissioner Wolf asked whether there was anyone wishing to speak in favor or in opposition to this application. There being no one, this portion of the hearing was declared closed.

Upon motion by Commissioner Lyons, seconded by Commissioner Hall, and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to close the public hearing on all applications and to open the public meeting.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Application #8054-23 Brigid Kennedy and Stephen Haynes, seeking to install twelve Tesla rooftop solar panels on rear roof of home at 285 Garden Street. (Last day to act: March 14, 2023)

Upon motion by Commissioner Gothers seconded by Commissioner Lyons and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to APPROVE the application as submitted.

Discussion

Commissioner Gothers stated that he thinks if they approve solar on the back of roofs, it shouldn't matter that it's a corner house because if they deny them because it's a corner house, they should deny any solar that goes on the back of a house that can be seen from anywhere. He's not denying that it's clearly visible, but he looks at that block ... his point is that they would eliminate that whole block to the next side street because if he's standing on Fernwood, he can look and see every single house.

Commissioner Wolf stated that they do treat houses on corners differently because they do have more visibility. They can see everything on the back of the house like if they put on an addition. They also have precedent and they have denied solar on the back roofs fairly recently on Hubbard Place and there are some that came in for front and back that were denied and then put on an outbuilding. They do have an outbuilding that has a back facing roof that would be a better consideration in this case. They have a precedent of denying them on corners like this where they are this visible. They did approve them on a garage on Garden Street and on Smitty because it was set back further, the angle of the roof, and there was a very narrow view between the house next door. It's important to remember that they do have to deal with every property individually and that includes its precise location. They would love to have rules that were set where they could say they are going to do this on every property, but as they learned in the public meeting they had about revamping the handbook, they can't even do that with fences because of the placement of the fence, the quality of the fence, so even on things that aren't on the main body of the house that are structures that are more temporary than fences and other structures, she thinks it is problematic. With that said, she doesn't think that the solar on the body of this house because of the location of the house, prominently located across from Stillman, in a place that you can see it, in an area where precedence dictates that they haven't done it before, she's not in favor of it, but she's one vote out of five people voting today, so she's interested to hear what other people have to say. They do have to resolve the issue of how that conduit is going to work if the majority of the votes are in favor of it, she thinks there needs to be something said about how that conduit is going to come down. They have a statutory mandate that says from public view. From 2019 to 2022, they approved 18 applications. From 2017 to 2022, the denied 10. Out of those 10, three of those are included because they were later approved on a portion of the house or in a different location. There are times when it will work and times when it won't. This has been an evolving issue. The products have gotten better and better. The panels they are seeing now are much better than the ones from 15 to 20 years ago. They are closer to the roof,

matte finish, they don't have a design or pattern in them. They still are waiting to see their first shingle or shake style roof in the District. They haven't had an application go to fruition, but she thinks that the products are getting better and better and she actually just saw a new tile roof product that looks exactly like a tile roof. If a tile roof was appropriate for your house, these are amazingly close to what you would see in Florida. So, hopefully, they will get better as they go on.

Commissioner Hall stated that he would just back up Commissioner Wolf's statement about precedence because the minutes from why the Hubbard house was refused includes Commissioner Meade saying that it's a very clear view from Fernwood from multiple housing perspectives. So what that tells him is that the Garden Street view is just as valuable to a homeowner as the Fernwood Street view from multiple angles.

Commissioner Raymond stated that he was walking down Garden Street and from either side of the house, you can't see the back of the house, but if you go down Fernwood, it is a billboard up there. He walked around to Hubbard and you have a clear view of the whole back of the house.

Commissioner Lyons stated that he had a good feeling that he was okay with this on the back of the home. They asked a lot about the conduits. They had a representative here and what if they don't do what they said they are going to do today. He agrees with Commissioner Gothers because they came back with just rear panels.

Aye: Gothers

Nay: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall

Upon motion by Commissioner Wolf seconded by Commissioner Hall and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to DENY the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Wolf stated that in her opinion, panels on this house in this location with its prominent view from the street on the corner, it does do irreparable harm to the property and to the District as a whole if they allow solar panels on this particular house. It's not appropriate for the era of this house.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall

Nay: Gothers

Application #8057-23 Juliano's Pools, seeking to install a 4' black aluminum fence in rear yard to surround an 18'x36' in-ground pool at 56 Broad Street. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

Upon motion by Commissioner Raymond seconded by Commissioner Wolf and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to TABLE the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Raymond stated that with the options that they've been given, they need some samples and a possible site visit to a location where they can see the modern style fence. He thinks that they need to get an idea of what that would look like and if it would be appropriate and then, from there, they can make a decision.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Application #8058-23 William and Nicole Liska, seeking to construct an 8'x21' open porch on front of home with TimberTech Porch flooring in Coastline color and TimberTech railings in matte white color, ThermaTru entry door, Palight trimboards, Abtco beaded ceiling, and carriage-style light fixture at 21 Chesterfield Road. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

Upon motion by Commissioner Raymond seconded by Commissioner Wolf and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to TABLE the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Raymond stated that he thinks that in looking at the roofline and some of the materials, he's hung up on the design and how it blends into the house and he doesn't want to necessarily deny this application. He thinks it's got some good opportunity.

Commissioner Wolf stated that Commissioner Gothers showed a drawing of how it might be accomplished more easily. How would they get usable width? Would they make the floor of the porch lower? Is there room for a porch on the side of the house?

Commissioner Gothers stated that instead of ... not even bungalow ... they are trying to figure out what look does ... because it kind of reads as a cape even though it's not a cape ... it's a ranch but it kind of reads as a cape. He thinks the pitch of the roof has a little steeper pitch to it and then when you put the little bump into the front. So, what he drew was instead of having the bump, just come from the ridge. Even though it would be asymmetrical, just make a straight line because there is a lot of roof left on the house and if they made all straight planes, and introduce the little kick-out in it...No. They just extend from the ridge because they are only bumping out 4'. How do they keep that long, flat plane without the kickout?

Commissioner Cutkomp stated that to do what Commissioner Gothers is proposing, they'd have to go through the chimney. It's bumping out 8'.

Commissioner Hall stated that his concern is that's the last original side of that house. That house has been altered everywhere else and if you talk about conserving a prominent style house whether you say ranch or cape that is almost a gateway to other houses that are similar and you are going to change it, he'll say what he said at the last meeting, he doesn't think they should be putting a farmhouse porch on and that's not what they're here for. They could see about getting an easement for the side. That façade is the last thing that says this house has been here for a long time.

Commissioner Lyons stated that he would agree with Commissioner Hall, but if you look at Oldham for argument's sake, there are 12 homes there. Probably 8 of those 12 have been significantly changed since the early Bosworth time.

Commissioner Symonds asked if they could they enlarge what they already have on that side?

Aye: Raymond, Lyons

Nay: Wolf, Hall, Gothers

Upon motion by Commissioner Hall seconded by Commissioner Wolf and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to DENY the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Gothers stated that it's not their job to redesign the project.

Commissioner Wolf stated that it alters the façade of the house in a way not keeping and therefore, is inappropriate for this property.

Aye: Wolf, Hall, Gothers

Nay: Raymond, Lyons

Application #8059-23 Ekret Llukaj, seeking to reface front steps and lower portion of front porch with stone veneer, install railings, and stone pillars in front of home at 6-8 Middletown Avenue. (Last day to act: March 28, 2023)

Upon motion by Commissioner Wolf seconded by Commissioner Lyons and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to APPROVE the application with the following stipulations:

1. Front steps are approved as submitted.
2. Brickface and skirting stones shall be removed from the body of the house to show original siding or with original siding to be restored to match body of house. The lattice under the front porch shall be replaced or restored with framed wood lattice.
3. Lights shall be removed from the front porch on the house and also removed from the lamppost.
4. Brick posts (pillars) at the end of the walkway along the sidewalk shall be removed.
5. The gutter downspouts shall be moved back to the original location at the back of the porch, abutting the body of the house and away from front of porch.

Discussion

Commissioner Wolf stated that obviously this is a difficult situation, however, she thinks that they all agree that the brickface has to come off the house, the porch and the porch skirt needs to be reinstated with the framed lattice underneath. The application of the lights on the porch itself is inappropriate and those need to come down. The style of the light on the post in the yard also needs to be changed so that needs to be removed. She thinks that they can soften those stairs by removing the big posts at the end and, thereby, removing the posts, you're removing the ornaments on top of them as well. These changes will bring this back to as close as they are going to get to the original and the changes will have a minimal impact on the District.

Commissioner Lyons stated that he agrees with Commissioner Wolf. He thinks that what takes your eyes away from those stairs is the railings that have been there for a period of time. Reconstructing that porch is not an easy task but it's something that can be done.

Commissioner Gothers stated that if they look at the stone veneer that they put onto the stairs, it's a tile mat that they put on there and people use them as a backsplash in their houses. A veneer brickface would look better than a modern looking/inappropriate veneer that they put onto those stairs.

Commissioner Raymond stated that he's grateful that they came in. There's no doubt that they put a lot of work into this, but it is completely inappropriate for this house.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall

Nay: Gothers

Application #8061-23 Michael Lueken, seeking to install a 3'6" high iron fence in front yard with five (5) 5'6" high bluestone columns to be constructed between fence sections at 362 Middletown Avenue.

Upon motion by Commissioner Wolf seconded by Commissioner Raymond and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to TABLE the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Wolf stated that she thinks the applicant has some nice ideas. They are evolving in the project and he's coming back with some other additions so she thinks some time to think about the modifications to the fence will be perfect.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Application #8062-23 Brendan Droney, seeking to install 19 roof-mounted solar panels on front and rear roofs of home at 19 Middletown Avenue.

Upon motion by Commissioner Wolf seconded by Commissioner Lyons and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to TABLE the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Wolf stated that the applicant didn't come today and they have plenty of time to review this with them.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Application #8063-23 Natalie Real, seeking to install a 73' long wood floating dock into the Cove at 310 Hartford Avenue.

Upon motion by Commissioner Wolf seconded by Commissioner Hall and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to TABLE the application.

Discussion

Commissioner Wolf stated that the applicant didn't come in tonight and it's a big project and they will need more information. She was going to ask for pictures to know what it actually looks like.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Application #8064-23 Earthlight Technologies, seeking to install 14 roof-mounted solar panels on rear roof of home at 77 State Street.

Upon motion by Commissioner Lyons seconded by Commissioner Hall and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to APPROVE the application as submitted.

Discussion

Commissioner Lyons stated that when they are looking to approve a solar application that this one would stand out as an example. They provided information on the panel array, where the conduits were going, where the meter boxes were going as well. It will have a minimal impact on the District.

Commissioner Wolf stated that she agrees completely with Commissioner Lyons. It's a dream solar application with all of the details present. She thinks that the mechanicals tend to become invisible to you over time because, like when you're driving down the street, you don't notice the telephone poles and in the neighborhoods that don't have them, it seems more wide open, but it's a necessary evil for sure.

Commissioner Raymond stated that his only concern is the driveway side because it has full exposure to the mechanicals. He knows they have to be there because that's where the box is but it's very visible.

Commissioner Hall stated that he drove through the area and unless all those trees were cleared out by man or nature, you won't even see it.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall

Nay: Gothers

MINUTES OF FEBRUARY 14, 2023

Upon motion by Commissioner Lyons seconded by Commissioner Raymond and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to APPROVE the meeting minutes of February 14, 2023, as submitted.

Aye: Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Abstain: Wolf

OTHER BUSINESS

Public Comments on General Matters of the Historic District

Certified Local Government Program - Gioia Zack, Director of Economic Development; Chris Traczyk, Chairman of the Heritage Commission; Fred Presley, Town Manager; and Mary Dunn, State Historic Preservation Office appeared before the Commission. The program opens opportunities for funding to preserve the historic treasures. It doesn't add any additional requirements that they don't already have to do according to the state statutes. They are missing one resume from a new member. They need a little bit more in the bios or a resume. They would like at least two professionally qualified people on the Commission and people who are interested/dedicated to historic preservation. Commissioner Hall asked a question about the training of the Commission. Mary Dunn stated that is her job. The federal partner will probably have zero say in what they do aside from giving the Commission money. The state review board is their body and they are all required to have professional qualifications. That doesn't apply to the HDC. She will review all of their questions and prepare her responses. The funding could be used for construction but the funds would be limited. It's used for workshops for property owners or walking tours. It's historic preservation education and planning. The main applicant would get the grant money. Without this designation, they can't apply for the funds. Commissioner Lyons asked if there was a finite amount for each program. The federal money, all historic preservation offices across the country get a certain amount of funding based on population and 10% of that funding has to be distributed to the Certified Local Governments. They don't get a whole lot of funding so the 10% doesn't amount to a lot but it's basically a non-matching grant of \$20,000 per project. You can only have one at a time. The community investment act is

state money. They put in place a program of up to \$30,000 for Certified Local Governments. That does require a match, however, if you want to do a town survey, a historic resources inventory, they could give \$30,000 with no match. This funding could be used to update the listing of historic properties because it's outdated and needs to be updated. There are currently 54 towns listed as Certified Local Governments. If there are further questions, she would be happy to come back. The money would typically be used in the Historic District, but it could be used throughout the town.

Commissioner Wolf stated that the lawsuit on Main Street has been resolved in their favor and he has 20 days to appeal.

Commissioner Wolf stated that they are working on an enforcement order on the arbor on Robbinswood. A certified letter went out and the next step is to turn it over to Counsel.

Report of the Historic District Coordinator

None.

Correspondence

Commissioner Hall attended the last town council meeting and the Town Engineer, Derek, will be submitting more proposals for lamp posts and a replacement of the light fixtures on the light polls.

ADJOURNMENT

Upon motion by Commissioner Gothers, seconded by Commissioner Hall and a poll of the Commission, it was voted to ADJOURN the meeting at 9:52 PM.

Aye: Wolf, Raymond, Lyons, Hall, Gothers

Respectfully Submitted

TOWN OF WETHERSFIELD
HISTORIC DISTRICT COMMISSION

Chris Lyons
- Clerk -